

The tower that appears a different color from each of the four directions surrounding it. Its surrounded by purple brush and thorny cerulean flowers. Titmice lump about in colorful clusters like handfuls of fluffy plumage.

Glorious pearlescent, iridescent, incandescent stones built from a mineral forged in highly pressurized dreams pave the paths through the plentiful courtyards.

And plentiful they were, both in number and in content; every structure was built with a special stringy phenotype of living marble. Statues depicted figures from legends yet to be written.

The tower's sole inhabitant was a count, and by that account it could be said by all accounts he could count as any account you might want to count him as, though when accounting for prestigious titles such as Count, he had no interest.

No, in truth, he was a wise old man of splendors. A magician of most excellent prestidigitation. Well, was he especially wise? Such things, I suppose, are subjective.

I of course am talking about him, and he of course is talking about myself. One eye an almond-oval of bittersweet jewels and the other dilated and stretched from years of beyond-vision. Six sectors of brain estate split apart by mental politicking, these sorts of things made it unclear how she should be referred to.

Have you seen a glass prism? Of course he has. But as for *you*, it is one of the most primitive channels for magic, such that it can be called a science by me.

"But the purpose being, it takes one stream and discerns it into several. Time would behave similarly, if time were a thing that behaved at all," I said.

Did he understand? Only kind of; but there were more than a few lifetimes to think it over.

What was I doing right now? Stroking an object in a manner most fierce, apierce. Apierce is apiece, but surface-level-wise-penetratively. It was a map, or maybe two, or maybe three, or maybe two. But probably eight, because that's how many sides the tower faced outward to the eight insovereign orphaned child states whose parent country did not exist.

Here come now a question, emerging with bubbling from the murky consciousness sea leaking from the ears like chemical aftermath of incidental reactions tenfold.

"If I die without ever having finished my work, will I have died in vain?"

She chuckles.

"Flip the question around," they have the magistrate to say, "like this:

"If I die in vain, will I without have ever finished thy work?"

That's the same question!

"Of course it is. All things are the same forward-and-back, because that implies there's a forward and back at all. Your forward is my back, your back is my forward, your forward for my back."

"That is to say, there is no unfinished work. All moments of existence are as complete as any other. Something can change or it can remain as it ever was."

Of course that's the perspective that would be taken from one with hundreds of scrawled pink bamboo parchments lined with fruit-purple zig-zagged lines, each could be viewed with a glass that magnifies to see words written for worlds that once were.

What of they, they whom became witness to the spikes of hurtful ground; taste the dirt so as to see the sky?

Death is of course death, you say.

Hardly seems so, say I.

A brass scale in a chamber just below drips ichorous saplike sand. So sumptuous and pouring a golden liquid, it unfurls a drop only once an interval decided as arbitrarily as minute physics. It can ooze, it can tremble, but it won't drop until its prepared.

Eels spin through the air, electrified by sight and sound and not electrons. They trembled when the ichor trembled. A creature that lives only for pleasure, they were tube-portals to memories.

Every drop made the scale excite. Heavier. When it reached a certain point, it would spill. The honey-ilk ichor would flow down through the icheducts and bring life to the flowers outside. So rich and delightful—

And ironic! As the ichor came from the flowers' pollen, coalescing in one singularity as a result of clusters of weaving electromagnetic compii (the future plural of compass).

The icheducts today were clogged by writer's blockages. No more data could be come up with to be written into the long-term pipe memory.

Thus bring unto he a servant most peculiar, bulging green at the nose and red at the bottom; a shape like an ocarina, hard rocky appendages instead carved in rather than holes.

“All of ye with the prettiest minds, matter ne too terrible to leave my treacle lips, despite it me’ve no choice te only te relay. A’block’a writah delay garden galore.”

“You are humble, thrall,” I yell, “but gaze into my terrible and brilliant technicolor crown!”

The crown was not a piece of apparel, it was a part of a body. Miracle of light!

A writer’s block was only temporary, definitionally. Such could be found in the list of all that was rather than all that wasn’t.

“Fuh’give me treacle lips! Me treacle treacle lips!” cried the thrall, thirsting for life. It could be heard on its treacle lips.

You were in a good mood that day.

“Craving for freedom, are we, thrall?”

The thrall tried opening its mouth to speak, but you cut through its meek Pygmalious (resembling that of Pygmalion, who does not exist in this world) words with a booming voice.

“Then have it!”

“Surely not masters plural great! Twhat haven’t I never been done to des’surfed a’fate’suh’great? Outlast reward times one for enduring miseries millions?”

She laughed, in that way that he always does.

“One mustn’t suffer for reward! If life were only the trying paddling push-and-pull of pain for pleasure, why mightn’t anyone choose to live it? Nay, my beautiful cherub ex-thrall born with the candylike button-nose of darlings delight, life is best described with the sorts of flowers I keep in my garden.”

“Alike te’ smillyboppa’s and the post-reincarnation carnations?” it asked like a suckling child.

“Your confusion is reasonable for one with a brain made of candyfloss and cotton balls!! See, my garden is only my garden. If the smillybops and reincarnated carnations are what makes you sneeze with a smile, then yes!

“But what flowers would you plant in *your* garden, wretched-nay-beloved homunculus sweetmeat?”

The ex-thrall cheered, whooped, and galloped around the room, scratching his hindquarters and leaving a trail of peppermint flakes behind.

“Igetchit! Igetchit! Tousand tanks ya islands chained together in the southern peninsular! I’d kiss your eight collective feets had I a tongue not made of sugar rock n’da wet sloppy syrup saliva!”

The ex-thrall ran from the room and fell down a flight of stairs. Don’t worry, though, he lived. Homunculi (future plural of homunculus) are very resilient.

She chuckles. Being a father was hard. If you love them, let them go. And if you let them go, you will love them.

Even still, I hoped the writer's block would clear up soon so the gardens wouldn't melt. The thrall never was necessary for groundskeeping, only learning a lesson. And a lesson was learned by you. Even at this wise old age, I truly can keep learning.

Suddenly, a deep rumbling in their stomach. Something was passing. A dream was passing. He breathes heavily and pants. Beads of rainbow-colored sweat leak from far too many pores. The uglier side of magic. She rose from an ancient wooden chair cushioned with glass pillows to get to the chamber pot.

The chamber pot, in contrast to the rest of the tower, was remarkably dull. It was made of gold, sure, but had not been polished in too long. The sorcerer count, who was no Count at all, heaved air through bearded whiskers. Even a magus must keep their chambers clean, and that logically follows to the pots as well.

After all as is taught in auteur auspicians (one who practices auspiciology, the kind of thing that you crack wishbones for) school codes of conduct, an unclean chamber pot was an unclean mind, which probably explained the recent insuppressible visions of intense, graphic, and regrettable fecal fellatio she'd been suffering from as of late, like cases of the midday vapors—only a brown fever as opposed to scarlet.

Who lets a bad play run in the theater of the mind? Anxiety worked quite similarly, and was not a phantasmagoria to cast like a spell. It would cast you first!

This was not a question any wizard in the vicinity could ponder at this moment, too busy they were with passing a dream into the molden goldy bucket. Here it comes...

The dream was a simple one: I want to fly past the barriers my feeble body will allow. Yes, he can see it all. Verticality was a heuristic for the mortal mind, and allowing that one placeholder one could quickly understand why a creature of the mud might look up past the grass blades and want to go past them.

Well, it can be done with enough teamwork and love. You will need to repurpose what's in front of you by seeing it as what it isn't and if you delude yourself enough like that one day you'll fly past space into the next big thing after that, but there will be another bigger thing after that.

That's all part of the dream though.

When the dream had passed, I sought to clean the chamber pot. It was long overdue. The sky pulsed like purple veins. Well, he supposes, the moral of the story is to clean your toilet.